🌻 !Contribution Analysis and Causal Mapping

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https://ieg.worldbankgroup.org/evaluations/quality-guidance-contribution-analysis-practice/quality-guidance-contribution-analysis

Causal Map: The IEG guidance is a kind of join-the-dots for evaluators. It treats causal pathways as stories to be told rather than networks to be analysed. If **Vocational Training** and **Peer Support** both influence **Confidence**, and that both that and **Micro-loans** together boost **Household Income**, the guidance just tells you to "populate the links" with evidence. It has no formal way to disentangle these overlapping influences or quantify which path actually has the most evidence behind it. You are using narrative sticky tape to join links that might not belong together.

The Contribution Analyst: That is a bit cynical. We are not just telling fairy tales. Step 4 of the framework is a mandatory hunt for "Alternative Explanations". We do not just look for evidence that **Vocational Training** worked; we actively try to debunk it by looking at things like **Improved Health** or **Local Market Trends**. It is a process of abductive logic: we seek the best possible explanation for the observed change.

Causal Map: But you are still falling into the "Transitivity Trap". The guidance assumes that if you verify Link A and then verify Link B, you have successfully evidenced the whole path. It ignores the risk of stitching together evidence from different people or contexts that do not actually overlap. I use "source tracing" to ensure every single indirect path from **Intervention** to **Outcome** is evidenced in its entirety by coherent sources. You are just assuming the ends meet in the middle.

The Contribution Analyst: I admit there is a constant tension here. We often wish we just had one direct arrow from **Intervention X** to **Increased Income** so we could compare the strength of evidence for different programmes directly. But that is an impossible oversimplification. The reality is always multiple interlocking steps. By breaking the theory into modular "contribution claims", we make the evidence for each piece explicit. If we have strong evidence that the training improved **Confidence**, and separate strong evidence that **Confidence** led to a job, that is a robust logical chain.

Causal Map: That does not really solve the problem that **Confidence** (or any other immediate influence on the outcome) might have been influenced by your intervention but also by other things. Plus, you are subject to verification bias. Because you are "theory-first," you are encouraged to look for evidence that fits your existing arrows. In a complex web, this leads to cherry-picking a coherent narrative while ignoring the messy, alternative paths like via **Improved Health** that might actually have a much higher strength of evidence. Finally, you cannot "query" a narrative. Once you move beyond a simple linear chain, trying to synthesise a "performance story" manually becomes cognitively overwhelming. You are trying to navigate a bowl of spaghetti by looking at one noodle at a time. With causal mapping, I can say, for example, "show me all the stories from X to Y via Z, told only by women".

The Contribution Analyst: I will grant you that manual synthesis has its limits. If the context is a "poly-crisis" with twenty different drivers, our narrative can start to fray. We rely on the evaluator's skill to keep the story honest and the evidence transparent.

Causal Map: Could we agree that the real world is a “contribution network,” not a simple chain. The IEG guidance provides the logical discipline: forcing us to test alternatives and stay grounded in plausibility. However, causal mapping can help with the structural rigour to handle the transitivity of hundreds of indirect paths. We should stop treating a Theory of Change as a fixed script and start treating it as a network to be queried. We need the network lens to handle the messy reality of how **Interventions** actually reach an **Outcome**, while using the CA steps to ensure we are making a tested claim rather than just drawing individual arrows.